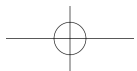


Plays Well in Groups

*A Journey through the World of
Group Sex*

Katherine Frank

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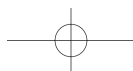
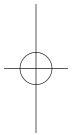
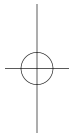


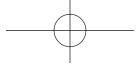
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Chapter One

The Elementary Forms of Group Sex

August 2010, Black Rock Desert, Nevada

It was a dark and stormy night.

Well, dusty, anyway.

I tightened my fur hood against the spraying wind. Wearing goggles, industrial-strength dust masks, fur bikinis, and yards of pulsating electroluminescent wire to make us visible in the darkness, my comrades and I blinked our way into the wheel of camps making up Black Rock City.

For one week a year during the Burning Man festival, Black Rock City becomes one of the largest cities in Nevada, an intentional experimental community built on utopian ideals and rebellious nihilism. Quite literally another world, the “playa” at Burning Man briefly becomes home to around fifty thousand people. The event engages all the senses: crazy, colorful outfits and gigantic art installations that contrast with the starkness of the desert landscape; smells of dust, ash, and gasoline; scorching hot days and freezing cold nights; incessant music. Groups of citizens explore on foot. Bikes whiz along the curved streets. Art cars, the only motorized vehicles allowed as transportation at Burning Man, inch through the city at five miles per hour—sea creatures, buses, cupcakes, boats. At night, green lasers cut across the sky and lights stretch along the horizon, punctuated by giant bursts of flame.

Like a mirage, the city disappears on Labor Day.

A “temporary zone of altered reality” is an ideal place to be an anthropologist, especially one who studies sexuality. People shed parts of their identities and many of their inhibitions when they step out of their everyday lives. New systems of order and meaning emerge just as readily, although the results are not always predictable.

Tonight, we were on an expedition.

"Not too much farther," I yelled.

The wind whipped at the shelters along our route, pulling tent flaps loose from their stakes. Even the RVs weren't impervious to the driving sand. A sunshade dangled from a silver Airstream. A screen door banged back and forth on a Tioga Ranger; its generator gurgled, faced with a torturous death from dust clogs.

An ancient double-decker bus, lit with orange lights, pumped music into the wind, waiting for visibility to improve.

We were searching for the infamous "Orgy Dome." It was my third pilgrimage to Burning Man and I still hadn't found it. Truthfully, I hadn't even seen much sex yet, though I'd heard the stories: "a bunch of hippies having sex orgies in the desert," "sex, drugs, and house music," "make sure you avoid the orgy tents." I'd happened upon a few BDSM demonstrations and a workshop on sexual technique. A campmate had enthusiastically tested both the Spank-O-Matic and the Orgasmatron—she was always good to have along in the field. I'd seen three people making out on an art car, clothes on, "orgy lite." But not much more. It was unconscionable not to follow up, given my profession.

I was also curious.

As always when one confronts stories of orgies happening somewhere but hasn't personally seen any, one starts to wonder why. Were we too "vanilla"-looking to get invited? Did we not know the "right" countercultural representatives on the playa? Maybe we're not orgy material out here, regardless of how we fare with invitations back in the real world?

Or maybe all the orgy stories were told by hopeful frat boys or paranoid critics?

After all, there's the reality of Burning Man to consider. Playa dust is fine and powdery, but sticky. It gets into every crevice of your camping gear, clothes, and body. No number of baby wipes can compensate for spending a week at a desert rave without running water. Good sex spots are hard to find. RVs and tents offer little space to maneuver for a couple, much less a group. If you crawl into a remote piece of artwork, hoping for a quickie, you'll likely get jumped either by rangers using night vision devices to scout for drug dealers or by a frazzled San Francisco sculptor guarding his creation. And while it might seem intriguing to stage an orgy underneath "the Man"—the giant, centralized effigy that symbolizes, in true postmodern fashion, whatever you want it to and that is ritually burned on Saturday night—doing so will get you a quick trip to jail in Reno.

Thus the legendary allure of the Orgy Dome: a temperature-controlled oasis, sheltered from the prying eyes of the authorities. Towels, fresh water, and double mattresses, trucked all the way from Los Angeles for our orgasmic pleasure—could it really be true?

We were determined to find out.

Why do some people have group sex?

Group sex was depicted in Paleolithic cave art. The ancient Romans are known as much for their orgies as for their aqueducts and bridges. The Egyptian queen Cleopatra supposedly had sex with more than one hundred men in a night—tell that to all the folks who boast of being her reincarnation. The sex parties at the Hollywood Playboy Mansion are legendary, as are the orgies in Hollywood film, from *Ben Hur* to *Caligula* to *Eyes Wide Shut*. The Kennedys are rumored to have hosted sex parties at the Hotel Carlyle in New York City. Contemporary sex parties take place in trailer parks, private mansions in the suburbs, converted warehouses, and luxury hotels from Las Vegas to Venice.

Stigma often befalls those who fail to lock the bedroom doors, yet some people have always defied norms of sexual privacy—fascinating or outraging others in doing so. Based on ethnographic observation, interviews with participants, memoirs, journalistic accounts, academic publications, and personal experiences, this book offers a cross-cultural look at some of the manifestations and meanings of group sex: who has it, how they do it, and *why*.

Such an inquiry requires abstaining from judgment while we journey through the fields of biology, anthropology, and psychology. Keeping an open mind might not be easy at first, as group sex incites responses ranging from fear and disgust to fascination and arousal—sometimes all at once.

Group sex, after all, is *transgressive* (yes, even for those college coeds seeking another girl on Craigslist for their boyfriend's birthday "three-some"). Although anthropologists have identified few, if any, true human universals, taboos are widespread against exposure of the genitals, public displays of sexual behavior, and multiple consecutive partners. Having sex willingly in the presence of observers or with multiple participants crosses a line of social propriety in many societies. Where these lines are drawn is, of course, highly variable. Take the fact that promiscuity for women is fairly predictably discouraged, though not universally forbidden: when former French first lady Carla Bruni admitted to having fifteen lovers before marrying Nicolas Sarkozy, some labeled her a slut. Some found her count remarkably behind the times for a woman of her age. *Only fifteen?* Others—like myself—wondered how impressive her list of conquests might have been if she'd been a bit *more* adventurous, given rumors that she'd already ticked off Mick Jagger, Eric Clapton, Kevin Costner, Vincent Perez, Donald Trump, and former French prime minister Laurent Fabius, along with philosophers, other musicians, and eventually the French president. But in the same country where Bruni was quoted as saying, "Monogamy bores me terribly," poor women from a growing immigrant Muslim population still face threats of beatings, gang rape, and even murder if suspected of impropriety, which might mean simply talking in public to a nonrelative who is male. Regardless

of the relative nature of promiscuity, however, having group sex is likely to get one labeled as promiscuous quickly. Group sex also transgresses expectations of monogamy in relationships and prohibitions against public nudity. Group sex participants are more maligned than either the plain old promiscuous or good old-fashioned cheaters because they break so many rules at once and do so in the presence of witnesses.

Of course, in a few times and places, group sex had loftier associations. Links between ritual sex and spirituality have been found throughout history, and words such as “bliss,” “passion,” and “ecstasy” can describe both spiritual and sexual highs. Ritual group sex, some scholars believe, marked natural cycles and transitions in certain tribal societies, such as when crops were planted or harvested or when couples were married. It was also purportedly used to attract the attention of the gods for favors. Whether these ancient rites were primarily sexual or primarily religious is still debated. Some of these rites must have been more religious than erotic—for example, sprinkling goat blood on the crowd was supposedly customary before orgies at Dionysian festivals. But does ritual animal dismemberment sit well with *your* libido? Some rites sound amusing—imagine dancing drunk around a giant wooden phallus as it is paraded through town on the way to a sex party. If that doesn’t make you snicker, well, perhaps your ancestors hailed from Tynnavos. Some rites seem cruel, even if arguably symbolic as well—as when a young virgin couple in a South Seas community was supposedly chosen to copulate publicly during a giant feast and then ceremoniously crushed under a pile of logs.

Christian authorities eventually clamped down on bawdy European pagan rites—canceling Greek phallic celebrations, banning the creative use of sausages in Lupercalia festivities, and doing away with the ritual sex, cross-dressing, and other impieties of Bacchanalia. By the time the church began burning witches at the stake for, among other crimes, dancing “naked, lasciviously,” and holding orgies “where incest and homosexuality prevailed,”¹ sex was firmly associated with sin and shame in mainstream religion. Group sex, as we shall see, was thought even worse. Christian missionaries spread these ideas far and wide, so although the older anthropological literature describes a sprinkling of ritual sex practices in places such as the South Pacific, Asia, and South America, contemporary enactments are rare. Sex, and occasionally group sex, remains sacred for some pagans and neo-pagans, and some Western Tantra practitioners believe sexual practices can amplify spiritual experience. Overall, however, sex has lost its connection to the divine in most contemporary organized religions.

One shouldn’t forget, of course, that before they immolated suspected witches for their “sinful” and depraved ceremonies, some early Christians had themselves been accused of similar crimes by the Romans, crimes such as holding secret drunken orgies, “involving the most reckless incestuous sex

between men and women of all ages” in addition to slaughtering children, drinking blood, and worshipping the genitals of their priests.² Groups that challenge mainstream beliefs, whether they are religious or not, may find themselves associated with orgies regardless of the accuracy of such claims. Even today, Wiccans have difficulty dispelling myths that their initiations involve secret midnight sex rites. In fact, charges of orgy hosting go along with all kinds of fearmongering, sometimes used to justify violence or oppression against particular groups. During the genocide in Rwanda, for example, Hutu extremist propaganda featured cartoons of Tutsi women having orgies with Belgian paratroopers and UN peacekeepers.³ Stories about the customs of the Yanomami Indians of Brazil—including allegations of crazed orgies and bizarre or violent sexual practices—were used to provoke interventions against them. Is it surprising that such stories accompanied the discovery of gold on their lands? Before quite literally losing her head in the French Revolution, Marie Antoinette was charged with losing her marbles in orgiastic excesses. Accusing an enemy of sexual depravity is a long-standing political tactic.

Unless we’re talking about children (or teens). The corruption of this particular group often signals the collective failures of a nation. In 2003, a guest on *The Oprah Winfrey Show* described “rainbow parties” to a horrified audience—oral sex parties where girls wore different shades of lipstick and boys collected rings of color around their penises. Commentators jumped on the story: What did this mean about American society? How could the youth of the nation go so wrong? By 2005, however, although admitting that oral sex was growing among teens, sex researchers remained dubious about how many actually participated in such parties. Rainbow parties are now dismissed as an “urban legend” rather than an “epidemic,” though the media attention may have given some teens (and adults) ideas. Also in 2005, reports of teens engaging in after-school “daisy chains” caused panic among parents in London. Though the term “daisy chain” often refers to a circle of people performing oral sex on each other, in this context public health professionals used it to denote a wider variety of group sex activities by teens that was supposedly leading to higher incidences of STDs. According to some French parents, British perversity infected their teenagers through a cult television series called *Skins*. The show inspired a series of parties—*le Skins* parties—where the youth “cavort in little more than their underwear” or masks, hold “adolescent orgies,” and “lose themselves in sex and drugs.” Defenders suggest that *le Skins* parties are “tame compared with what goes on at the *clubs echangistes*,” or the swingers’ clubs popular with the older generation, and that the teens kiss but rarely go further.⁴ Sadly, reports of gang rapes at high schools—such as the 2009 gang rape and beating of a teenage girl outside a California high school while other students watched or videotaped with cell

phones—make rainbow parties, daisy chains, and *le Skins* seem downright quaint.

Group sex is often illegal as well as taboo, though restrictions vary. Throughout history and around the world, venues used for group sex are targeted in sex panics. Fears of sexually transmitted disease and crime, such as prostitution or illegal drug use, lead to sex clubs or parties besieged with “cleanups.” Such fears—often unfounded—also impact legislation, arrests, and prosecutions. In an infamous raid in May 2001, fifty-two men were arrested on the “Queen Boat” in Egypt, a floating gay nightclub, for “habitual debauchery” and “obscene behavior.” In 2010, Ma Yaohai, a college professor from Nanjing, China, was sentenced to three and one-half years in prison for “group licentiousness.” His actual crime? Organizing swingers’ parties for consulting adults. Of the twenty-one people arrested and charged with Ma, eighteen received jail sentences. Although such punishment seems harsh, Chinese commentators note that Ma Yaohai might have been sentenced to death twenty years ago, when attitudes toward sex were more conservative.⁵ In April 2012, eighteen men were arrested in Manhattan Beach, California, in a sting at a public restroom. After police were alerted about “unusual activity” in the restroom, they began monitoring online conversations about the facility, eventually arresting the men on a variety of charges: “soliciting and engaging in lewd conduct in a public place, loitering, utilizing a peephole in a restroom, invasion of privacy and indecent exposure.” The men’s photos were posted online.

Despite potential stigma and legal penalties, consensual group sex occurs around the world and among people of varying sexualities, ages, ethnicities, and other social distinctions. Some libertines, accomplished at the art of the orgy, have been wealthy, famous, or powerful: Caligula, Hugh Hefner, Silvio Berlusconi. *Bunga bunga, anyone?* Most, however, are not. Some participants are gay, lesbian, or bisexual; many are straight. Though group sex participants may self-segregate based on sexuality, age, race, attractiveness, or other considerations, the link between practices and identities is rarely straightforward. Group sex is something that some people *do*, regardless of what they call themselves. Men who advertise on Craigslist and then meet for late-night sex in a hotel room may identify as gay or straight; some couples at a sex club might identify as “swingers,” other people as “open” or “polyamorous,” and still others as “just willing to party.” Some individuals prefer group sex but rarely have it. Some alternative sexual communities involve group sex more than others. What starts as practice—men having anonymous group sex with men in public parks, for example—can become vital to identity formation. Or not. Precisely *how* identity becomes important in different scenarios and in relation to participants’ erotics should be explored rather than assumed.

Sex isn’t just sex; group sex isn’t just “sex + 1 + 1 + 1.”

Bathhouses, sex clubs, and erotic parties catering to gay men thrive in urban areas worldwide, as do those drawing heterosexual couples. “Dogging,” the most notorious British sex fad of the millennium thus far, is a form of heterosexual cruising in public parks or large parking lots. Doggers also arrange group sex encounters involving multiple voyeurs and participants through e-mail or text messages; such technologies are well suited to participants’ needs for both anonymity and speed, as encounters must be completed before police are alerted.⁶ (If you have an Android phone, there’s an app for that. . .) One researcher suggested that 60 percent of UK country parks were affected by dogging in 2003,⁷ with its popularity growing. American “wife swappers” and revolutionary free lovers of the 1970s have given way to diverse groups of “swingers” around the world. Also termed “the lifestyle,” recreational nonmonogamy among couples has seen a resurgence due to the use of the Internet to meet partners and the growth of erotic couples’ tourism to places like Hedonism in Jamaica or Desire in Mexico. Not all swingers have group sex—some swap partners and “play” in separate rooms—but many do. “Hotwife” enthusiasts, or men who are turned on by watching their wives having sex with other men, trade stories online and arrange gang bangs at hotels.

Looks like orgies aren’t just for the Romans anymore!

Men claim more voyeuristic fantasies than women across cultures; not surprisingly, they are more avid pornography consumers. Studies conducted around the globe also find men fantasizing more about group sex than women and expressing more interest in actually participating in it.⁸ Reputable studies of sexual fantasy are lacking in most non-Western locales, however, and comparing sex differences in the desire for group sex is difficult. People sometimes respond to surveys in socially appropriate ways and may be ashamed to even discuss sex, much less admit to transgressive fantasies. A US study found that only 1 percent of women found the idea of group sex appealing compared with 13 percent of men.⁹ But when *Marie Claire*, a popular women’s magazine, features articles on threesomes, dogging, and swinging, one could say that group sex has an increasing presence in American culture.¹⁰ (Across the pond, the French daily *Le Figaro* similarly reported on the regularity of threesomes among youth and quoted an eighteen-year-old woman as suggesting that threesomes were “a good way of spicing up your love life.”)¹¹ In Pensacola, Florida, a savvy defense team wanted to argue that their client’s adult website hadn’t violated community standards of obscenity. Using Google Trends, software that analyzes the popularity of search terms, they found that “orgy” was more prevalent as a search term in Pensacola than “apple pie,” “ethanol,” or “boating”; “group sex” beat almost all nonsexual search terms it was compared with as well.¹²

“Gang bang” porn is a thriving niche in a worldwide industry. In 1995, Grace Quek, otherwise known as Annabel Chong, achieved infamy with the

film *The World's Biggest Gang Bang*: she set a world record by engaging in 251 sex acts with 70 men. The competition has gotten stiff (and probably sore), however: Lisa Sparxxx currently holds the world record at 919 men in a single day, a title she claimed at the Third Annual World Gangbang Championship and Eroticon 2004, and Sabrina Johnson engaged in two thousand sex acts during a two-day event in honor of the new millennium. Records are held for the largest transsexual gang bang, gay orgy, all-female gang bang, and “reverse” gang bang (one man with numerous women). Porn waxes creative as well as competitive when it comes to group sex, however. Bukkake porn, originating in Japan but since spreading around the world, showcases group scenarios where multiple men ejaculate on a woman’s face or body. Japanese porn directors also bring us “fucking contests,” “dildo races,” and other orgy-themed game shows. Japan also boasts the record for the largest orgy, a choreographed production of 250 couples copulating in synchrony. The video, *500 Person Sex*, is available online.

Take that, Cleopatra.

Not all group sex, unfortunately, is consensual. Gang rape has been used to control and punish for centuries. Although the last reported incident in the group occurred in 1940, the Mehinaku Indians of the Amazon used the threat of gang rape to prevent women from entering sacred male space.¹³ Similar threats, direct or indirect, have been used in the United States to keep women from competing in male-dominated sports, covering news stories in war zones, and attending military academies such as the Citadel. Gang rape is prevalent in prisons around the world. In the United States, a 2010 report suggests that more than one hundred thousand people a year are sexually assaulted in prison; many of these are group attacks.¹⁴ Transgendered prisoners are at an increased risk for gang rape, especially if they are housed according to their birth sex rather than other factors, such as a feminine appearance. Victims may even be punished when they turn to the courts. In some Muslim countries, rape victims can be charged with “fornication” or “adultery” if they are unlucky enough to become pregnant from the assault; male victims can be arrested for homosexuality. In 2007, a nineteen-year-old woman was gang raped in Saudi Arabia for meeting with a man who was not her relative. Though her seven rapists were given prison time, the victim was also sent to jail and given up to two hundred lashes. After the violence of the 1990s in the former Yugoslavia, mass rape was successfully prosecuted as an act of genocide, although gang rape has occurred in warfare for centuries.

At the same time as violent group sex can maintain order by establishing hierarchies or enforcing the status quo, out-of-control group sex—the stereotypical, excessive *orgy* depicted in Western literature and film—is associated with both individual and social breakdown. Aldous Huxley’s *Brave New World* ends with a scene of frenzied sex and violence while the crowd chants, “Orgy-porgy, orgy-porgy.” One of the most scrutinized scenes of Stanley

Kubrick's 1999 film, *Eyes Wide Shut*, is the orgy scene of masked participants, which ends in the murder of one of the prostitutes involved. It is impossible to forget the literary (and real) orgies of the Marquis de Sade, which he explicitly invests with revolutionary—and cautionary—meaning. Orgies, it seems, rarely end well. Losing control sexually is believed to have a domino effect on one's individual morality and sense of self as well as on society as a whole.

Something far more significant than “boot knocking” is going on here.

Still, there isn't a lot of information to be found about group sex if you want more than titillation or advice on where to find it. *Gang Bangs and Group Sex* is a collection of “true submitted tales of orgies, gang bangs, groups, public sex, incestuous parties, and many other taboo and exotic erotic events.” (It comes in a Kindle version, better for those reading on airplanes.) If you don't know the “ten commandments of orgies,” you can pick up *Sex Parties 101* or *Nina Hartley's Guide to the Perfect Orgy*. Don't forget, you probably need a date if you've managed to score an invitation: you might want to buy *Getting Your Wife or Girlfriend to Become a Swinger*. If you're a gay guy looking for group action, there are dozens of books and websites to help you find it: check out the *Spartacus International Sauna Guide & Bathhouses*, which has a multilingual edition.

Yet academics have barely touched the subject of consensual group sex since the 1970s publication of a book called—you guessed it—*Group Sex*, which was actually about swingers. Searching for “orgy” in the academic literature will find it used metaphorically as an example of out-of-control excess or in reference to a scene in a film or work of literature; only rarely will it refer to sexual activity. Group sex is sometimes brought up as a form of risky sexual behavior in the context of the HIV crisis, particularly for gay men. Research on contemporary heterosexual “swingers” focuses more often on the cerebral aspects of the topic—jealousy in couples or negotiations between participants, for example—than on what people are doing with their bodies.

But what *are* people doing?

Let's take a tour—quick, before someone shuts us down.

The journey begins with the symbolism of “orgies,” looking at historical accounts, art, and literature, from the ruins of Pompeii to the beaches of Tahiti, and then moves on to examine group sex practices around the globe. Violent group sex is explored: “jackrolling” in South Africa, mass wartime rape in Bosnia, and group assaults on college campuses. Recreational group sex participants appear as well, from individuals who use Craigslist Casual Encounters to lifestyle couples looking for a “rock star” experience. You'll peek inside businesses catering to group sex participants: BDSM clubs, swingers' conventions, and gay bathhouses. You'll hear from people who have group sex and people who wish no one would have group sex. The

quest for altered states of consciousness through group sex is investigated, from “sex addiction” to “cosmic ecstasy.” Along the way, a series of questions is posed about how group sex dramatizes relationships between individuals and between the individual and society: What can we learn about human sexuality more generally by exploring a form of behavior that is not only taboo but relatively widespread across geographic locales and time periods? How does the human propensity to experience disgust, shame, or guilt affect the meaning of group sex, either as violence or as union? What do our tendencies to both regulate sexual activity and repeatedly break the rules teach us about desire? And why is group sex so emotionally and symbolically powerful?

ANTHROPOLOGY IN THE BEDROOM (AND ELSEWHERE)

I never set out to write a book on group sex.

My original research questions about sexual desire and fantasy first sent me into strip clubs—while working as a stripper—to study the motivations and experiences of the other dancers. But after working in the clubs for a few months, I became much more interested in the regular male customers. Why were these men willing to spend so much money for an interaction ending with a hefty credit card bill instead of an orgasm?

While my approach to gathering data seemed unconventional to some, it was in many ways quite traditional. As an anthropologist, I was committed to participant observation. *Do as the natives do*, the famous anthropologist Bronislaw Malinowski suggested, to truly understand how other people live. His research on Kula exchange among Pacific Islanders, at first glance, appears worlds away from my exploration of why so many married, middle-class men enjoy folding dollars into the G-strings of young women. Yet, at some level, both practices are about establishing identity, forming relationships, displaying status, and acting in ways that feel deeply personal to the individuals involved but are embedded in cultural systems of meaning. How better to understand what people thought they were doing in strip clubs as well as what they were doing without realizing it than to actually participate in those interactions? My questions thus first emerged as I observed strip club “culture” as an outsider, but they were answered only as I immersed myself in that world.

While working as both a stripper and an anthropologist, I learned that many of the committed customers were struggling with monogamy. They loved their partner and wanted to remain faithful; at the same time, their desires for *more*—more sex, more connections with people, more freedom, more understanding—sent them questing into the clubs. This search for more became the basis of my next research project. In it, I explored how people

thought about sexual and emotional exclusivity in different relationships—monogamous relationships, those where one spouse or the other was secretly cheating, and open relationships. How did people define “cheating”? Why do people ask their partners to “forsake all others” physically, socially, or emotionally? In addition to surveying and interviewing couples for this research, since the mid-1990s I have attended swinger (or “lifestyle”) events, parties, and conventions in the United States, Canada, Mexico, and Europe. Again, I took on multiple roles: as a single woman, as part of a couple, as a hired stripper, as a researcher, and as part of a convention crowd. And after a time, I again “went native” and began negotiating monogamy rather than expecting it in my own relationships. Sometimes my personal questions aligned perfectly with my intellectual inquiries. Other times, as when I unpacked my suitcase after an anthropology conference and repacked it for a lifestyle party in Miami, trading slacks and blouses for shimmering bikinis and Lucite heels, I was aware of inhabiting two different worlds. Once again, my questions developed out of multiple perspectives: outsider, insider, anthropologist, participant.

My interest in writing this book on group sex was to broaden my analysis of human behavior. After years of focusing intently on specific communities and field sites, I wanted to think about sexual practices more generally. I also realized that because of my experiences as a stripper, in the lifestyle community, and as a sex researcher who rarely passes up opportunities to explore erotic nightlife, I had developed another unique combination of insider/outsider perspectives on a form of human sexual behavior that is not necessarily rare but that remains a mystery for many: group sex.

So—have I been to a real *live* orgy?

I knew you’d ask.

Yes. I’ve been to orgies where the rules were strictly enforced, right down to when one’s clothes were removed. I’ve been to sex parties where nervous couples huddled together until the wee hours, gulping drinks and wondering who would make the first move. (Sometimes no one does.) I’ve been to week-long events, where parties were interspersed with zip-lining adventures, visits to Mayan ruins, or a group excursion to Cirque du Soleil. Occasionally the participants were famous; sometimes they were stay-at-home moms, contractors, or schoolteachers. I’ve gone to house parties, BDSM sex clubs, swingers’ clubs, orgies hosted by movie stars and musicians, and lavish invitation-only events where potential participants are screened by existing club members. I’ve been to parties where the rules of engagement became more nebulous with each line of cocaine disappearing from the nightstand, and where group erotics became a way to fight for attention rather than express desire. (And yes, there were catfights, tears, and girls sent home in taxis—all the dramatic elements that make you suddenly wonder, at 4 a.m., whether you’re being filmed for a reality show.) So I’ve seen a lot of

group sex. In fact, I've seen so much group sex that I can discuss the weather or the irritations of rush-hour traffic as the action unfolds around me. Nude bodies—even copulating nude bodies—have lost any impact they once had.

But perhaps I am a different sort of person in this regard anyway, as walking into an orgy always sent my thoughts spinning more toward Freud, Durkheim, or Bataille than to sexual pleasure. My curiosity, not my sex drive, stimulated my explorations of human sexuality in the first place. In fact, part of my intellectual fascination with sex stems from the fact that sex is *not* itself very significant to me: I enjoy it but I don't crave it, feel guilty having it, or worry much about whether my fantasies and desires are "normal." I am, however, captivated by transgression. People from all walks of life regularly risk *everything* for sexual experiences—their relationships, jobs, health, and even their lives—and endlessly seek ways to push the boundaries of acceptability. Others never find the courage to explore the things they secretly or shamefully fantasize about and spend their lives struggling to control their sexual desires. Still others choose to explore but live complicated "double lives." I am interested in why sex means so much to so many people and the underlying reasons for cultural and personal struggles over sexuality. And I am also interested in why we are so often told "no" when it comes to sexual exploration.

In some settings discussed in this book, I had firsthand, participant, observer,¹⁵ or research experience. Although I did not anticipate writing this book, my interest in sexuality, disciplinary training in cultural anthropology, and previous use of participant observation as a research tool meant that I paid close attention to details and social dynamics in these settings. My informal observations became important as this project took shape, as did my tendency to analyze my experiences through an academic lens. Thinking about group sex from such an insider's perspective presents an intriguing opportunity. Because sex is generally private, researchers studying sexual behavior rarely observe people in the act. Instead, they rely on reports of what people *say* they do in the bedroom, and as we all know, people don't always tell the whole truth about what they do and why (nor could they if they wanted to, as some motivations are unconscious). But I had the chance to watch and, at least in some settings, ask questions. I developed ongoing relationships with participants involved in different sexual enclaves. My own experiences became a source of questions and information.

As contemporary researchers increasingly study in, or write about, their own communities, questions arise: Where does research begin and end? Which identity—participant or researcher—is most salient in a given situation? How does one write about people, places, and experiences without jeopardizing confidentiality or violating one's personal boundaries? Both to protect the confidentiality of others and direct attention toward a bigger picture, this book is not a "tell-all" or confessional memoir. If an experience

is recounted in the regular body of the text or the name of a person, place, or event is presented there, it has been rendered as accurately as possible. Interview material is identified as such, and while these sections are edited for clarity and confidentiality, substantial changes have not been made here, either. These interviewees were men and women of different sexualities, ages, races, social classes, and nationalities, although they cannot be said to be representative of any particular population. The italicized sections are composite narratives drawn from both my experiences and those of people I interviewed over the years. These sections provide sensory details, illustrate themes emerging in the discussions, or hint at the diverse meanings of group sex experience.

Places where group sex occurs are not universally accessible. Women, both lesbian and straight, are usually turned away from bathhouses for gay men, for example, except on special occasions. Single men are not welcome at many sex clubs catering to couples. And despite popular misunderstandings about the inclusiveness of “orgies,” invitations to sex parties are not extended to everyone wishing to attend. The interpretations and observations given here thus reflect the privileges and disadvantages of my sex, age, appearance, race, social class, and nationality. Whether or not I had firsthand knowledge of a particular setting, I sought interviews with experts and drew on published scholarly work, which is admittedly sparse. Sometimes I invited people to send their recollections of group sex experiences or drew from published memoirs. Journalistic accounts and blogs also provided information about how group sex is conceptualized, practiced, and policed, although I was limited to material produced in English or that could be translated. These sources allowed me to include relatively recent or obscure events that had not appeared in the peer-reviewed literature, although it is important to remember that journalistic pieces are written with a particular audience in mind; many newspapers, websites, and news blogs recirculate the same stories.

Examples of group sex from multiple countries appear here, although a lack of reliable cross-cultural data makes it impossible to systematically canvass the globe. If a BDSM club in Germany is discussed, the information should not be taken as generalizable data about *all* Germans, *all* people involved in BDSM, or even all Germans involved in BDSM. Further, although many of the group sex participants discussed here are relatively privileged and have access to the Internet as a means of seeking partners or information, this does not mean that consensual or recreational group sex is unique to these populations. Global and local power dynamics affect the stories that can be told about various places and the aspects of sexuality deemed possible and worthy of study. Are there sex parties in Khartoum, for example, that might have been described to balance the discussion of gang rape in Darfur? Just because I have not found accounts of swingers’ clubs,

bathhouses, or erotic parties in Sudan in the mainstream press or the academic literature does not mean that some people there do not pursue pleasure, adventure, and escape through sex. But in some countries, the legal and religious climate, along with the politics of gender, sexuality, and ethnicity, make it both risky and difficult to conduct research on sexuality. Journalists and scholars may focus on sexual violence, sexually transmitted diseases, or the perils of reproduction because these are serious issues faced by populations around the world, but also for practical reasons—people are understandably reluctant to share their experiences when sex is considered shameful or if they risk criminal penalties. Scholars may also fear being stigmatized at home or in the field. Even anthropologists who have observed, heard about, or partaken in consensual group sex rarely write about their experiences. Because the research on consensual group sex is heavily biased toward the United States, Western Europe, and Australia, I have included examples of violence from these places as well. Such a strategy is an imperfect solution to the problem.

Historical data is also challenging to evaluate. Some accounts of sexual customs in tribal cultures, for example, were produced by missionaries or colonial officers. Although some of these individuals were also excellent observers and ethnographers, others were untrained or primarily interested in controlling the populations or managing public opinion back home. Sometimes, our knowledge of a supposedly customary practice is based on a single description or on retrospective accounts given by community members who may not have even participated (and probably had good reasons for including or leaving out certain details). Thus, while we cannot expect multiple observers to have reported on tribal customs in the 1700s, we do need to contextualize existing accounts and be aware of how they are retold over the years. When it was impossible to verify particular descriptions of group sex using reasonable or contemporary academic standards, or even to trace them back to an identifiable source or ongoing debate, these accounts are usually explored as myth or discourse, as there is still much to be learned from how people talk about group sex.

These are limitations faced in every chapter. Nevertheless, this book offers privileged descriptions of some of the ways people have group sex. Beyond that, I also hope to shed light on some of the *whys*, on the personal and cultural meanings with which group sex is endowed.

MAKING SENSE OF SEX

Why do people have group sex? And what does it mean when they do?

Scientists distinguish between proximate and ultimate causes for behavior. Proximate causes are the closest explanations of a phenomenon; ultimate

causes are its underlying reasons. The existence of both kinds of explanation, importantly, invalidates neither of them. Many of us are not aware of the underlying reasons for our behavior, though it is still meaningful to us and to others. Parental investment theory, for example, predicts that women will be more selective than men in their mating practices because their costs of reproduction are greater and the obvious benefits of having multiple partners are reduced. Even if a female mates with one hundred males in a year—or in a day, like Cleopatra or Annabel Chong—she can still only bear one child in nine months. Parental investment theory thus suggests an ultimate explanation for why women around the world generally report fewer sexual partners than men in surveys as well as less interest in group sex. More information is necessary, however, to explain why *some* American women still have more sexual partners than some men, enthusiastically participate in college “hook-up” culture, or refuse to count anal or oral sex as “sex.” More information is necessary to explain sexual practices among the Mosou in China, who once celebrated sexual freedom for women but have been harassed by the government into adopting more conservative attitudes.

My perspective on sexual behavior here is multifaceted and interdisciplinary. Human sexuality involves more than a universal drive to reproduce, although it has important biological and physiological components. Patterns of sexual behavior and meaning are shaped by historical, political, legal, and economic factors, cultural values, religious beliefs, distributions of power, gender norms and expectations, parenting styles, and ideas about love, sex, reproduction, and marriage. Parents, consciously and unconsciously, transmit their own beliefs and feelings about sex and those of their culture to their children. Sometimes these beliefs and feelings are contradictory, triggering anxieties and stimulating desires in both unique and patterned ways. Prohibitions against certain desires or acts are generated through individual histories and cultural norms; these prohibitions, in turn, can become exciting—and shameful—to transgress.

Group sex, as defined here, is *erotic*¹⁶ or *sexual activity that implicates more than two people and consists of various possible configurations of participants and observers*. Including erotic activity allows us to sidestep the numerous difficulties with defining sex: Do blow jobs count as sex? What do we call it if a married couple has sex while another couple watches them? Is a public demonstration of a violet wand on a “slave” at a kink venue considered sex? What if onlookers are allowed to participate? All of these activities might be considered erotic—although to different degrees—for at least some of the participants. Because my discussion ranges across place and time, however, I also discuss activities that may not be considered erotic by some or all participants but that still involve witnessing or being witnessed in sexual practices or situations—gang rape, defloration and initiation ceremonies, fraternity hazing, or bachelor parties, for example. Part of the difficulty

in studying across boundaries is that setting definitions beforehand forecloses some of our ability to discover what is going on and what any of it means to participants. On the other hand, without an idea of the territory we are interested in exploring, it is tough to come up with even a rudimentary map (or decide when it is time to turn around).

In any given encounter, participants may witness or engage in a variety of activities—kissing, masturbation, mutual masturbation, oral sex, vaginal sex, anal sex, and so on—with multiple or sequential partners. This definition covers orgies, “daisy chains,” bukkake, “horseshoes,” “circle jerks,” and the *ménage-à-trois*. Some group sex encounters are distinguished by the sexual activities that occur, as when swingers differentiate between “soft-swap” (no intercourse) and “full-swap” encounters or when gay men attend a “jack off” party where intercourse is forbidden. Such distinctions are important to participants who use them to state preferences or maintain boundaries. Such distinctions may also be important to public health researchers or others concerned with counting “risky” behaviors or changing practices. Here, however, it is the “group” aspect that is key to my inquiry.

Cross-cultural research demonstrates that desires for sexual privacy of some sort are widespread among humans.¹⁷ Only rarely is copulation allowed in public with any degree of social approval, for example, during rituals or “moral holidays,” such as a fertility rites or festivals, or during aggressive and sometimes punitive displays, such as a collective rape.¹⁸ Defloration ceremonies were occasionally performed publicly before marriage by the bride’s relatives or future husband. Some societies require public proof of consummation (and prior virginity) upon marriage, as when a blood-stained bedsheet is presented to family members or religious authorities. Fewer societies require, or allow, witnesses to intercourse itself, however. Some tribal groups purportedly held wedding orgies, where a husband’s friends or relatives publicly had sex with the bride. Other societies supposedly had such liberal attitudes toward sex that privacy was an afterthought. Unfortunately, because such examples are relatively infrequent, the same few accounts have been extracted and retold for decades, often becoming both decontextualized and politicized in the process. Sorting out truth from fantasy—or political spin—in such descriptions can be like a game of Chinese whispers.

Privacy is relative, of course. For groups such as the Siriono of Bolivia, for example, privacy was unavailable at night because family members shared tight quarters; appropriate intercourse thus took place in the late afternoons in the forest.¹⁹ Most societies also have norms of discretion, or “social rules against noticing or even discussing specific human actions” that serve as a substitute for, or supplement to, privacy.²⁰ Young people around the world have sex in cars out of necessity; sometimes the couple in the front seat pretend the couple in the back aren’t there. An American teen walking in

on his parents having sex would undoubtedly act as if it hadn't happened, although he might tell a busload of friends if he had interrupted two schoolmates instead. Specific notions of privacy are also cultural and historical. Modern American ideas about privacy, for example, have their roots in complex legal and political discourses, some of which recognizably emerged during the Victorian era.²¹ Discourses of public health and medicine add another layer of meaning: people who seek privacy for acts like urination, defecation, and copulation are considered more civilized, dignified, intelligent, or healthy than those who do not. Even bodily attentions of less consequence, such as bathing, shaving, or dressing, are considered private matters in the United States. A homeless person washing in a public restroom is more likely to arouse disdain than sympathy. The United States fosters a confessional culture with regard to inner feelings, thoughts, and desires, however; many disclosures that Americans readily make—sometimes even on television—violate norms of privacy elsewhere in the world. Still, desire for some level of “protection or escape from other human beings” is panhuman—that is, existing in every human society where conditions permit.²²

In 2008, Max Mosley, chief of Formula One racing, was caught on videotape engaging in kinky BDSM with five prostitutes wearing “Nazi” uniforms. The video caused a media frenzy. Mosley sued *News of the World*, the tabloid that broke the story, for breaching his privacy. He had a point. Group sex is not the same thing as “public sex.” Although group sex cannot truly be “private,” it *can* occur in private spaces such as homes or hotel rooms. The court agreed, and Mosley was awarded \$120,000 in damages (although he has not been successful at compelling Google to prevent discussions of the incident from appearing in searches). Public sex, on the other hand, is sex occurring in public places such as parks or nightclubs. Sometimes the presence of witnesses is important to the participants. But other times public sex is dyadic in intention, for example, when homeless individuals have sex in a crowded shelter or a couple have sex in an alley because they find it erotic. In these situations, norms of discretion are usually maintained; that is, unintentional observers avert their gaze rather than watch, masturbate, or attempt to join in.

Some psychoanalysts argue that even dyadic sex comprises more than two people at the level of fantasy. In addition to the couple, for example, sexual encounters could be said to involve each person's unconscious Oedipal rivals and Oedipal ideals—basically, the psychological remnants and elaborations of their parental relationships (or other significant emotional relationships, if we prefer to put Oedipus to rest). And if that doesn't make the bed crowded enough, we could invite the other fantasy figures that consciously, but often secretly, animate any given encounter—past lovers, the partner's past lovers, hoped-for future lovers, and any number of porn stars or celebrities. Some couples fantasize together openly about including others.

But although such complexities are fascinating, the focus here will be on situations where we could actually call for a head count.

My definition of group sex extends far beyond “orgies,” as is probably clear. The meaning of the word *orgia*, from which orgy is derived, is “secret worship.” Not that historical orgiastic practices were all that secret—Dionysian ceremonies in ancient Greece, for example, reportedly involved public drunkenness and “every aberration of sex, the one leading up to the other,”²³ which sounds more like a scene from MTV’s *Spring Break* than a clandestine woodland prayer circle. The word “orgy” implies that sexual partners are taken on indiscriminately, perhaps because participants have lost their inhibitions due to the power of ritual, the use of mind-altering substances (drugs or alcohol), social breakdown, or insanity. It also suggests that participants are all seeking pleasure, which is certainly not the case with violent group sex. Over time, the word “orgy” has expanded to denote unrestrained excess in a variety of forms—gluttony, drunkenness, and even murder (“blood orgy”). Because of these dense historical associations, the phrases “group sex,” “multiperson sex,” or “plural copulation” are often more accurate.

The term “monogamous” is used here to mean sexual exclusivity in a relationship, rather than referring to a form of marriage where individuals have only one spouse at a time. Group sex is by definition nonmonogamous in this colloquial sense if couples are involved, although not all kinds of nonmonogamy involve group sex. Religious polygamists, for example, may have sex privately with each spouse. Similarly, contemporary polyamorists, who have multiple romantic and sexual partners, do not necessarily have sex with more than one at a time—except on late-night television. Inuit “wife swapping,” where male guests were offered a night with an Eskimo’s wife in the name of hospitality, or suburban American “key parties” like the one depicted in the film *The Ice Storm* (1997), where the women pull a set of car keys out of a bowl and leave with someone else’s husband, are other examples of nonmonogamy that do not involve group sex.

This book does not address the question of whether monogamy is or should be the sexual ideal for humans, nor does it consider whether “swinging,” BDSM, or any other practice discussed is good or bad for individuals, relationships, or society as a whole. The focus here is on what people actually *do*. And some people have group sex. Some have a lot of it.

Some social scientists will see an attempt to theorize across practices, places, and identities as being invested with intellectual hubris, doomed to failure. Every concept we attempt to deploy across settings—culture, individual, ritual, and so on—can ultimately be deconstructed. Strict relativists might argue that the meaning of group sex is so different in Tehran that we can’t even begin to compare it with group sex in Atlanta. And if we are comparing heterosexual teens in contemporary Tehran and adult gay men visiting bathhouses in Atlanta during the 1970s? Forget it. Certainly, in some

ways, this is true. Developing the richest understanding of group sex in either setting requires much excavation, perhaps even years of study. Still, as anthropologists Robert Edgerton, I. M. Lewis, and others point out, a statement of incommensurability is already a comparison. From another perspective, then, it is interesting to explore patterns arising despite the variation. Some of the meanings of group sex overlap from time to time. People have group sex because it *does* things in human societies, and some of those things are similar across historical, geographic, and cultural boundaries. Some of those things are examined here, although I make no claims to have exhausted the possibilities.

Realistically, I am merely shouting out the tip of an iceberg. But, as those on the *Titanic* could attest, sometimes that can be a good start.

